

A VISUAL FIELD GUIDE

Make it read.

You already notice things.
Now explore how images help you notice.



One place. Many choices.

Try a different emphasis, path, gap, placement, focus, or view. Notice what changed. Change your mind as often as you like.

NO SCORE. NO SUBMISSION. NO PRESSURE.

Support for the September 9, 2026 Composition & Depth topic. This guide includes helper vocabulary and optional examples. It does not claim that every activity happened in class.

01 / COMPOSITION + ATTENTION

Give the eye a place to begin.

A frame can contain many things. Your choices help a viewer decide what to notice first, next, and after that.



A quieter doorway.



A brighter doorway. Same position.

WORDS THAT HELP YOU DESCRIBE IT

Frame

The visible area of an image. Its edges decide what we can and cannot see.

Composition

How visual elements are arranged inside the frame.

Focal point

The person, object, or area that draws attention.

Visual hierarchy

The order of attention among elements. Size, contrast, position, focus, and movement can contribute.

Contrast

A noticeable difference: light against dark, large against small, or still against moving.

A USEFUL DISTINCTION

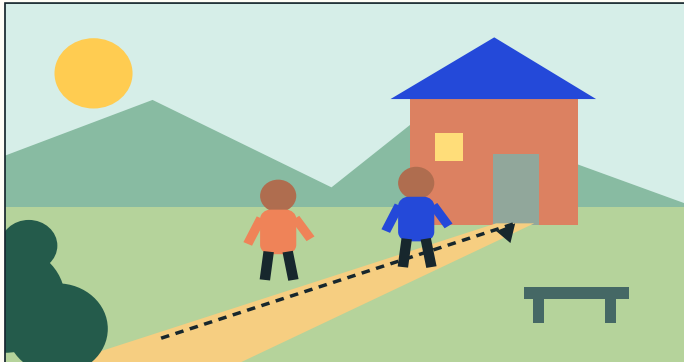
Biggest does not always mean first. A small bright doorway can stand out against larger, quieter shapes.

Bring it to a game. In a game, hierarchy can help a player find a meeting place, notice a partner, or read an important object. Test that prediction with another viewer.

02 / LEADING LINES

Make a route for attention.

Edges, paths, gestures, and repeated shapes can suggest where to look. A line does useful work when you can explain what it leads toward.



The path leads toward the door.



The path leads toward the friend.

WORDS THAT HELP YOU DESCRIBE IT

Leading lines

Visible or implied lines that guide attention through a frame.

Implied line

A direction suggested without a continuous drawn line, such as a person's gaze or a row of objects.

A USEFUL DISTINCTION

Not every line is a leading line. A decorative stripe may divide the image without guiding you to something meaningful.

Bring it to a game. Paths and environmental edges can suggest where a player could go. They do not guarantee the route is accessible or that every player will follow it.

03 / NEGATIVE SPACE + RELATIONSHIPS

Let the space say something.

The area around and between subjects is part of the composition. Changing a gap can change a possible reading, even when the people stay the same.



A smaller gap between people.



A wider gap. What could it suggest?

WORDS THAT HELP YOU DESCRIBE IT

Negative space

The less occupied area around and between subjects. It does not have to be blank or white.

Positive space

The area occupied by the main subjects or forms.

Spatial relationship

How things relate through distance, position, direction, and overlap.

A USEFUL DISTINCTION

Lots of space does not automatically mean loneliness. It could suggest freedom, scale, safety, anticipation, or separation, depending on context.

Bring it to a game. For a game about people needing each other, spacing might show an invitation to gather, a barrier to cross, or a person waiting for help.

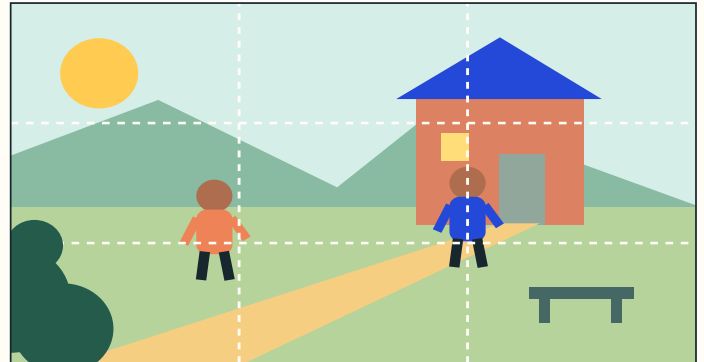
04 / THIRDS + BALANCE

A useful grid. Not a rulebook.

A three-by-three grid gives you positions to try. Centering a subject is also a choice. Ask what a placement communicates, not whether it earns a geometry score.



Center is a possible choice.



Thirds generate another possibility.

WORDS THAT HELP YOU DESCRIBE IT

Rule of thirds

A composition guide with two equally spaced vertical and two horizontal lines. You can test subjects near those lines or intersections.

Symmetry

A matching arrangement of shapes or positions on either side of an imaginary line, like a mirror relationship.

Visual balance

How attention feels distributed across an image. An image can feel balanced with matching sides or different shapes that hold attention together.

Visual weight

How strongly an element attracts attention through its size, contrast, or how crowded it is.

A USEFUL DISTINCTION

An off-center image is not automatically better. Symmetry can communicate stability, ritual, tension, or emphasis when the context supports it.

Bring it to a game. Use a grid as a way to generate alternatives. Then check the actual scene, screen size, and player task.

05 / DEPTH + DEPTH OF FIELD

Where it is ≠ how sharp it is.

These two ideas are related, but they answer different questions. Spatial layers describe position. Depth of field describes the range of distances that appears sharp.



Positions: near, middle, far.

WORDS THAT HELP YOU DESCRIBE IT

Foreground

The part of the represented scene closest to the viewpoint.

Middle ground

The part between the foreground and background.

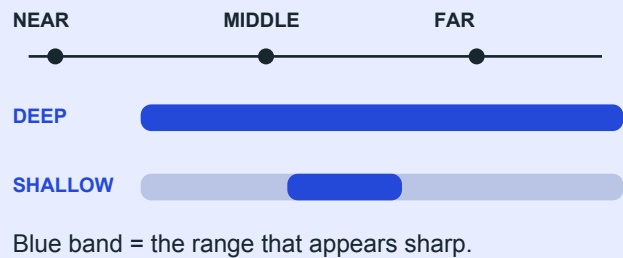
Background

The part of the represented scene farthest from the viewpoint.

Depth

The sense of near and far. Overlap, size differences, and lines that converge into the distance can suggest depth in a flat image.

SAME OBJECT POSITIONS



Focus: which distances read sharply?

Depth of field

The range of distances that appears acceptably sharp.

Shallow depth of field

A relatively narrow range of distances appears sharp; other distances look softer.

Deep depth of field / deep focus

A relatively broad range of distances appears sharp.

Focus

In this context, image sharpness at a selected distance. Attention and optical focus are not the same thing.

A USEFUL DISTINCTION

Blurring the background does not move it closer or farther away. A flat image can suggest depth even when everything is sharp.

Bring it to a game. An engine's camera can keep a partner sharp and soften the surroundings, or preserve several distances so the player can read the environment. Choose for the information the player needs.

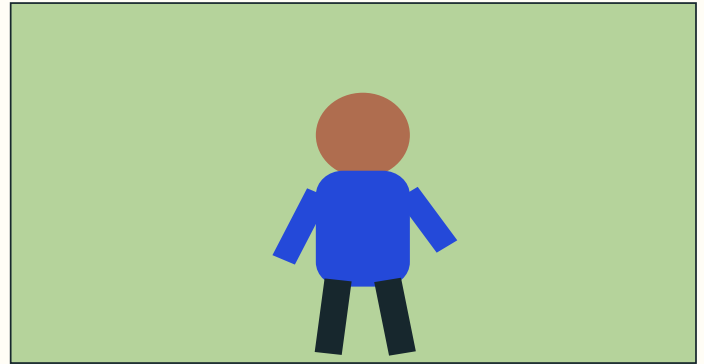
06 / ESTABLISHING + FOCAL ISOLATION

Help us know where we are.

A view can tell us where a scene happens and how its parts connect. Another view can emphasize one person while leaving less context visible.



More setting and spatial relationships.



A closer view, with less setting.

WORDS THAT HELP YOU DESCRIBE IT

Establishing shot

A shot that orients the viewer to a setting or to important spatial relationships. It is often wide, but its purpose defines it.

Wide shot

A view that shows a relatively large area around its subject. This describes the view's scale, not necessarily its function.

Framing

Choosing what appears inside the frame and how the edges contain or exclude it.

Blue Lock (visual)

Our course shorthand for making a focal character or object stand out through color, light, or position. It is an example of hierarchy, not a standard cinematography term.

A USEFUL DISTINCTION

Wide and establishing are not synonyms. A wide view may fail to orient us; several closer views can sometimes establish a space.

Bring it to a game. Show a bridge, a partner, and a destination together when players need to understand their relationship. Isolate a character when their action matters most, while testing what context is lost.

THINK, THEN PEEK

A little practice. A lot of permission.

Read an option, then its explanation. There is nothing to submit. You can learn from every choice.

01 / COMPOSITION + ATTENTION

A small bright doorway draws your eye before a large dark wall. What best explains it?

- A. The doorway creates stronger contrast.** A best fit here. Yes. Contrast can give a small element more visual emphasis. A second viewer may still notice something else first.
- B. The largest object must always be the focal point.** Size is one influence, not a rule. Compare the doorway's brightness with the wall around it.
- C. All viewers look in exactly the same order.** People can read the same image differently. Describe your evidence, then test the choice with someone else.

02 / LEADING LINES

You say, 'The path is a leading line.' What makes that observation stronger?

- A. It is a line, so no explanation is needed.** Try being more specific. What does this particular line help you find?
- B. Trace the path and show which subject it directs attention toward.** A best fit here. Exactly. Naming the route and its destination connects vocabulary to visible evidence.
- C. The image uses three colors.** Color may matter too, but it does not explain what the path is doing. Trace its direction.

03 / NEGATIVE SPACE + RELATIONSHIPS

A character stands in a large open area. Does the negative space prove the character is lonely?

- A. Yes, that is always what empty space means.** That is one possible reading, not a universal rule. The same space might feel peaceful to another viewer.
- B. No. Negative space cannot affect meaning.** Space can be expressive. Look at the scale, posture, surroundings, and relationship to other subjects.
- C. No. It can suggest a reading, but context and other evidence matter.** A best fit here. Yes. Offer a possible interpretation and explain what supports it. Stay open to a different reading.

THINK, THEN PEEK

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04 / THIRDS + BALANCE

A centered, symmetrical doorway is easy to notice. Must you move it to a thirds intersection?

- A. Yes. Centered composition is always wrong.** Centering can be deliberate and effective. What does this arrangement help a viewer understand?
- B. No. Keep or change it based on what the composition needs to do. A best fit here. Right. The grid helps you test choices; it does not replace your purpose or a viewer's response.**
- C. Yes. Every focal point belongs on the upper-right intersection.** There is no single correct intersection. Compare alternatives and explain their effects.

05 / DEPTH + DEPTH OF FIELD

Only the middle-ground friend is sharp. The other objects have not moved. What changed?

- A. The friend moved into the foreground.** Sharp does not mean near. Use position and scale to locate the friend, then consider sharpness separately.
- B. The room became physically smaller.** The layout stayed the same. A change in sharpness can change what is easy to read without changing space.
- C. The focus treatment changed, not the objects' positions. A best fit here. Exactly. You changed which distances read sharply. The foreground, middle ground, and background remain in place.**

06 / ESTABLISHING + FOCAL ISOLATION

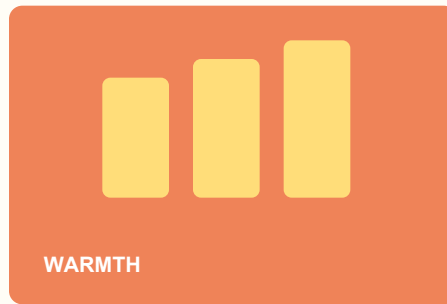
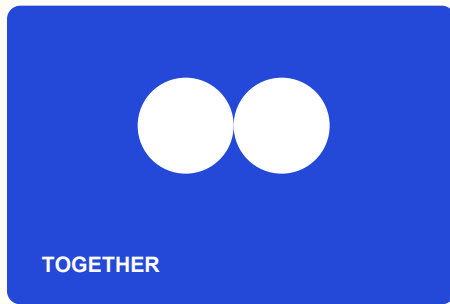
Which statement describes the function of an establishing shot?

- A. It helps us understand where we are or how the scene's spaces relate. A best fit here. Yes. The purpose is orientation. A wide view is one common way to provide it.**
- B. It must show an entire city.** A room, a meeting place, or a relationship between spaces can be enough. Scale alone is not the definition.
- C. It always uses shallow depth of field.** Focus is a separate choice. Either deep or shallow focus may serve a scene, depending on what must be understood.

NO PRESSURE. KEEP WHAT HELPS.

Make one deliberate choice.

Imagine a game where people need each other. Choose one feeling or piece of information you want the image to communicate.



TRY IT WITHOUT ANY SPECIAL SOFTWARE

Find one image, pause on a frame, or use the interactive studio. Say: "I want the viewer to notice _____. I will change _____ because _____." For course production, use a game engine (software for interactive games) or animation (images changing over time).

HELPER VOCABULARY / CONNECTING CHOICES

Moodboard

A curated collection of visual references that proposes the look, tone, and world of a project.

Palette

A selected group of colors and a plan for how they work together.

Visual cohesion

The sense that choices belong to the same world, even when they include intentional contrast.

Curation

Choosing and organizing references for a reason, rather than collecting everything you like.

THE MOODBOARD CONNECTION

These experiments can help you choose references and explain why they belong together. This recap creates no new assignment, grade, or deadline. Use the current course brief for assignment requirements.

NO PRESSURE. KEEP WHAT HELPS.

Let someone else surprise you.

Before you explain your intention, invite a viewer to tell you what they see. Their response is useful information, even when it differs from your prediction.

1 / SHOW

Let the image speak first.

2 / LISTEN

What did you notice first?

3 / REVISE

Choose one thing to test next.

WHEN YOU ARE NOT SURE WHAT TO SAY

Start with something visible: "I notice the bright doorway." Then offer a possibility: "It might be the destination." No need to guess the maker's intention.

HELPER VOCABULARY / CONNECTING CHOICES

Justification

Explaining why a choice belongs, with visible evidence and a connection to your intention.

Iteration

Making, testing, and revising a choice using what you learned.

Viewer test

Letting someone describe what they see before you explain what you intended.

Collaboration

People contributing to a shared effort and depending on one another. In this assignment it is also the subject of the imagined game.

A GOOD STOPPING POINT

You can stop after one observation. Save a screenshot or a short note if you want to remember it. Return when you are curious again.

YOU CAN PAUSE. YOU CAN SKIP.

Watch one thing. Notice one thing.

These links require internet. The explanations and illustrations in this PDF remain available offline. Choose a single clip if that is enough today.

Big Walk / House House / Panic

Watch up to 1:32. Pause on one frame. How do light, paths, and spacing help you find another person?

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vyQPc1i4Rpo>

Into the Spider-Verse / Sony Pictures Entertainment

Try 0:00-3:00 of the opening. You can stop sooner. Name what you notice first, then point to the feature that drew you there.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zzH4rV08TLI&t=0s>

Wilmot Works It Out / Hollow Ponds & Richard Hogg / Finji

Watch the short trailer, up to 2 minutes. How does arranging become something the player does, rather than something the player only looks at?

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=syfKNCYnz_s

IF YOU WOULD LIKE ANOTHER EXPLANATION

[Visual hierarchy / Envato Tuts+](#)

[Leading lines / Kellan Reck](#)

[Negative space / BBP Reel Insights](#)

[Establishing shots / StudioBinder](#)

[Rule of thirds / Learn Online Video](#)

[Depth of field / Never fStop](#)

ABOUT THIS GUIDE

CTIN 290 / Gordon Bellamy / Composition & Depth, September 9, 2026. Adapted from the course session plan and terms sheet. Original geometric illustrations and optional practice designed with AI assistance and prepared for instructor review. Helper vocabulary is included to support understanding, not to define an official assessment list.

"Blue Lock (visual)" is course shorthand, not a standard film term. Interpretations in examples are possibilities; a still image does not prove how every player will behave.

[Adobe / photo composition](#)

[StudioBinder / establishing shots](#)